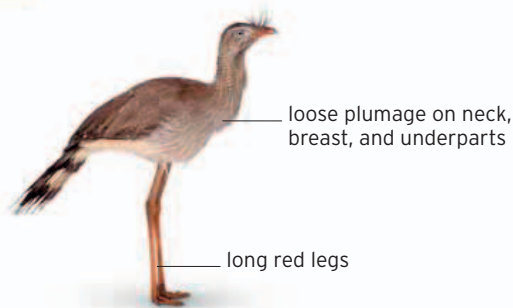




permanently raised crest of feathers at base of bill

# Red-legged seriema

*Cariama cristata*

Tall, long-legged, and gangly, seriemas share much of the same range and habitat as the larger rheas. They use the abundant termite mounds in grassy, savannalike scrub and bush as lookouts and song posts. The territorial males make the air ring with long series of loud yelps, with abrupt changes of pitch. These extraordinary sounds are audible over several miles. The head is flung back, bill wide open, almost touching the back at the loudest moments.

## Short sprints

The red-legged seriema's short-toed feet are adapted for running—in short bursts of up to 25 mph (40 km/h)—to escape predators, and for pursuing and stamping on tough and lively prey. The seriema climbs around in the lower branches of trees or flies up higher to roost. The nest is built within reach of a short series of fluttering leaps. Otherwise, flight is infrequent and short-lived, with quick flaps of the wings followed by long glides.

Seriemas kill prey such as snakes by beating them on the ground with their bill. They are sometimes kept as “watchdogs” among chickens to keep them safe. Seriemas prefer open and bushy areas, so are not threatened by loss of habitat and, at times, may even benefit from deforestation.



## △ THREAT DISPLAY

Males sing loud duets to reinforce territorial claims. If they still chance to meet, they use ritual postures to settle differences without resorting to fighting.

## ◁ DISTINCTIVE BILL

A seriema's broad, hooked bill is its main tool, grabbing, manipulating, and breaking apart large prey such as lizards, snakes, and tough beetles.

finely barred body plumage

- ↔ 30–36 in (76–91 cm)
- ⚖ 3 lb (1.4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🦎 Lizards, birds, rodents
- 🏠

